

SECRETS OF SUCCESS UNCERTAINTY, PROFITS AND PROSPERITY IN THE *GARI* ECONOMY OF IBADAN, 1992–94

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Over the last fifteen years the *gari*¹ supply system for the great urban centres of south-western Nigeria (Lagos, Ibadan, Abeokuta and many smaller towns) has been constituted and refined into a major sector of the urban food market. Its growth has been very substantially the work of the producers, traders, transporters, retailers and consumers. Before the decline in the value of the Nigerian currency began in 1986, and before President Babangida embarked on populist rural development projects, *gari* was not the main form in which cassava flour was sold in urban markets. Although cassava is one of the cheapest staple foods, it poses problems for mass consumption. It has to be prepared and dried, and the main method of doing that had been soaking and drying it into a flour known as *lafun* by the artisanal Yoruba producers. There is a limit on the volume that can be handled in this way. Fermenting, pressing and roasting into *gari* was a method developed in the east of the country, and was also done by hand. But because of the shorter time needed for preparation and the much smaller demand on water and drying space, *gari* production offered no major bottlenecks to small-scale mechanisation, which came primarily in the grating and roasting. As soon as the volume of production could be increased the stage was set for major expansion all the way along the commodity chain. Even in a very poor and insecure economy there are particular niches that can experience a spurt of growth, and the urban supply of *gari* has been one of them in Nigeria. One great centre has been Oyo, a town situated in the producing heartland, in the savanna, which - by virtue of its long-standing political importance—is on every major route to the rest of the country (Fig. 1).

This article examines not the growth pattern of the *gari* economy itself but the commercial practices of the women traders of Oyo who are largely responsible for the growth. The remarkable feature of Ibadan's food economy is that it is supplied in small, consistent quantities by many village and town women who trade on the narrowest of margins. I calculated, for example, that the net profit—to include labour costs—was under 10 per cent. The gains may be small and difficult to accumulate to a level that allows expansion into other domains, but they are nonetheless sustaining in their regularity and widespread distribution among the female population.

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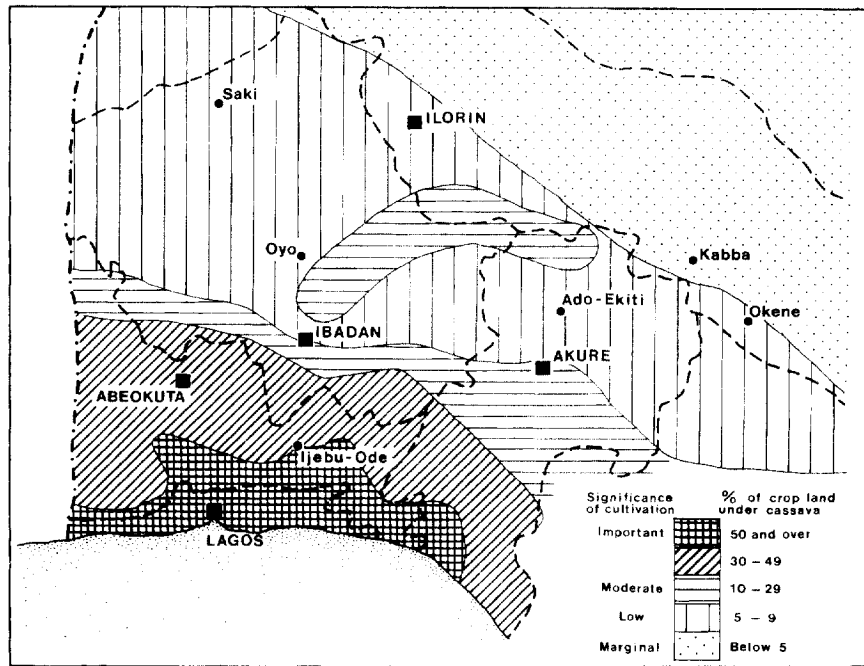


FIGURE 1 Cassava circulation c. 1970. *Source* Based on Agboola (1979), p. 61

No formal-sector financial or commercial institutions govern or mediate the gari distribution system. The entire complex edifice, with its thousands of operators, has to depend on reliability and trust. Yet the operators themselves cannot function through open processes. Their ability to make profits depends on skill at working at the juncture of two sets of considerations: first, they have to manage quite large quantities of goods, substantial sums of money and long time frames of turnover; secondly, they have to create livelihoods and meaningful lives for themselves and their dependants. The result of meshing the two concerns is a complex alternation of secrecy and display, even in a sector which must approximate the model of the perfectly competitive market, where almost all techniques are shared knowledge. To be successful in her profession a trader has to display her competence, and, in her personal life, to be judged a success she has to display her achievement. But at various stages of the turnover of goods and money secrecy is of the utmost importance. Pooling goods, money and reputation in one place and time, which is essential for display, is always dangerous. It risks loss from theft, shrewd reaction by competitors, jealousy or simply loss of traders' inside knowledge. It can be done only in a controlled fashion.

The article traces the stages of the distribution process in a rapidly expanding sector of the economy, describes where and how secrecy and

display are practised, and explores women's own commentaries on the techniques they use. I argue that the business techniques of the gari trade—the mechanics of buying and selling, supplying and restocking, accounting and bookkeeping—function to disperse women's incomes and savings, which enables them to pool quickly and confidently when necessary without holding. The management skill involved is remarkable. Although some traders are better than others, the entire system depends on these understandings and conventions that build on an existing Yoruba tradition of commercial knowledge and action.

METHODOLOGY

For the research I concentrated on activities in the market, where the greatest amount of interaction occurred between participants in the buying and selling of gari. Ibadan has two wholesale markets, Bodija, in the northern part of the city, and Orita Merin, in the centre of the old city. From observations made at these two markets, I divided gari traders into three categories: (1) traders who process cassava into gari and bring it to urban markets to resell: the *oloko* level; (2) traders who purchase gari in producing towns and villages and bring it to urban markets to resell: the *alàrobò* level; and (3) traders who purchase gari in urban markets from other traders to retail: the *oniremi* level. In Ibadan my field assistants and I identified seven shop owners in Orita Merin and six in Bodija who wholesaled gari. Shop owners were the most stable and easy to locate of all participants in the gari trade. Each one had her own stall and a set of apprentices. They frequently were in the shops early in the morning until the close of the market at 6.00 p.m. These thirteen shop owners were interviewed with a standard schedule of interviews about shop management, trends in the gari trade, accounting and investment, and their business and life histories. Although I visited each shop at least once a week, I worked closest with two shop owners at each market, attending their ceremonies and spending extended periods of time in their shops visiting and passing the day. In addition to interviews and questionnaires of the shop owners, *oloko* traders, interviews with apprentices and family members of the shop owners were also undertaken. These interviews capture the work of apprentices and the occupations and experiences of the children of shop owners. Gari retailers who occupy the lower ends of the trade in terms of profits and supply were not interviewed owing to gaps in field time.

Although it was easy to determine the costs of processing, transporting and selling gari, traders were extremely reluctant to detail their earnings and relate what they spent their money on. However, budgets for processing, a shop's commission over a year and the exact amounts spent on weddings, naming ceremonies and graduation celebrations were not difficult to collect. As I describe in greater detail, personal expenditures were only partially revealed. We tried to get round this obstacle by asking traders to detail their most expensive expenditures during the year in order to determine the most significant

demands on people's incomes. Many methodological issues are raised by focusing only on what expenditures people remember. While this approach may not provide a perfectly accurate account of a trader's actual aggregate expenditure over a period of time, large expenses incurred by illness, celebrations and house repairs represent significant investments of resources that by their planned or unplanned nature can easily be remembered.

UNCERTAINTY AND CALCULATIONS

Gari trading presents particular challenges in relation to risk and uncertainty. The production and supply chain involves not only the availability of standard resources of crop and transport but also the additional labour required to process cassava into gari. In general, traders in the food economy of southern Nigeria do not calculate the profitability of their trading ventures until the goods are sold. Therefore gari traders rely on a number of practices to mitigate risk and enable some control over uncertainty.

Uncertainty in the gari trade is characterised by the fluctuation of the retail price in urban markets. The urban food economy is highly sensitive to the availability of the supply of gari. Although gari traders recognise and anticipate the seasonal variations that are associated with major holidays and the dry season, they are less able to predict the daily price of gari unless they are continually cycling between processing areas and Ibadan markets. And although many can anticipate an upswing in prices during the dry season months of March and April, no traders I knew were able to stockpile supplies to profit from the price increases. I note in the following section some limited attempts to manipulate the price by withdrawing supplies. However, gari supplies originate from a variety of producing areas, which makes co-ordinated effort even more difficult in a highly competitive market. Furthermore, urban residents already maintain hostile and adversarial attitudes to traders, making any mention of price collusion incendiary. Planning for price uncertainties therefore entails safeguarding practices that are either specific to transactions or spread across a trader's trading assets.

The quick turnover of gari sales as a monitoring practice has a number of advantages over dependence on unit price. Selling gari quickly ensures that there is one uniform price per volume of supply. With this practice a trader avoids losing as well as gaining an additional margin of profit. Chances of additional losses and gains may occur in subsequent trading trips to Ibadan, but, for a specific supply of gari, traders resoundingly advocate a consistent price per *kongo* within a narrow time frame. In more practical terms, any delays in selling gari in Ibadan prevent a speedy return home. Specifically, delays in the city offer opportunities to spend more money while inconveniencing husbands and other family members at home. If sales are slow, women are sometimes obliged to stay several days as the guest of the shop owners. Although shop owners provide one meal for the traders as their guests, most women expect to spend more money on prepared

food and other items. As the selling days increase, traders are more likely to reduce the selling price of gari in order to return home. Slow gari sales entail postponement of the reinvestment of profits, if there are any. The longer a trader waits to return home the greater the cost to her initial investment.

In the best trading circumstances, traders arrive in the urban markets with the price of gari ₦1 more than they anticipated. Depending on the difference between their anticipated price and the actual market price, traders can wait for prices to rise and fall over the course of several days. At the very least, women are frequently fortunate enough to match their investments with their earnings after deducting transport expenses. For traders who process cassava into gari and resell in Ibadan, profit margins are considerably greater than for the alarobo traders who purchase gari for resale only. In the worst circumstances, traders arriving with large amounts of gari discover that the urban market price is in free fall. In this situation, they have two options. Many wait for the prices to readjust to a more acceptable level or they will unload the gari with the greatest speed to maintain their initial investment. As described below, experienced traders with sufficient resources can weather short-term price fluctuations.

It is true that prices are fluctuating but not all commodity prices are falling or increasing at the same time. So as an experienced trader, when prices of a good are not stable and sales of that good are not profitable what I will do is switch to another commodity. But if I don't switch, I will just continue the sales of such goods with the hope that after some time it will repay any loss that I may have incurred on it. Usually decreases in price and subsequent losses are not prolonged beyond two weeks before it is stable and it becomes a bit profitable and so we will continue to survive; thus we are able to cope with the continuous fluctuations in commodity prices. As an experienced trader who trades in more than one food item, if we are making a loss on one commodity, profits will be coming in from other items. (Alhaja Lawumi, 16 December 1993)

Fortunately for most gari traders, supply is usually running behind demand. In periods when the price falls below the acceptable profit thresholds, gari traders manipulate prices by removing supplies from the market floor. The withdrawal of gari from the market has limited effectiveness in most cases.

When traders remove gari from the market, they weigh the number of days they must wait to force prices up against their demands for reinvestment or immediate expenditure. Among the different types of traders, the processor-traders are more frequently willing to withhold gari in order to guarantee a certain price per kongo. Retail gari sellers are just as susceptible to a decline in the price but have smaller margins to lose. In the last week of February 1993 gari sales were slow and prices fell below the level acceptable to oloko traders. Although many traders anticipated brisk sales before Ramadan, gari supplies were more abundant and prices fell accordingly. For one week, traders withheld gari supplies but resumed sales when the price per kongo reached

₦8.50. Also traders from the Oyo area did not arrive in either Orita Merin or Bodija markets. Traders from the Oke Ogun area also stopped coming to Bodija when news spread to Ogboro that the kongo price of gari was ₦6 to ₦7.50 in Ibadan. Gari prices continued to climb to ₦9 by mid-March, when sales became brisk and traders were able to make acceptable profits.

During 1993 through 1994, prices for gari in the two markets had predictable surges and ebbs. Traders are well aware of price trends because such fluctuations are related, for the most part, to the holiday and festival cycles, and are possibly tied to the pattern of incomes from the cocoa harvest. From December to mid-January the supply of gari is scarce in urban markets as people rest from farming and other income-generating activities to travel to their home villages, attend local ceremonies and visit family and relations. Christmas, Id-El Fidtri and New Year are significant holidays in the Yoruba social calendar when feasting and celebrations remove people from their daily work schedules. Prior to these holidays, gari prices are relatively low in comparison with the mid-dry season (from the end of January to the end of April), when harvesting cassava is a difficult and expensive undertaking. During November gari supplies are plentiful as people work diligently to earn money for the upcoming festivities. As Christmas approaches, fewer people come to urban markets with goods from the hinterland. By the beginning of the year gari has become scarce and prices rise dramatically. Motivated by high prices and the quick turn-round of sales, more people return to processing and trading, and the price resumes its pre-holiday levels. Figure 2 illustrates the fluctuations in prices throughout this period.

Prices, however, are not the determining factor for all sales in the gari trade. As I discuss below, it is difficult for a gari trader to use price as a sole indicator of economic performance. I suggest that, apart from the kongo or bath unit price, quick sales turnover is the crucial and determining influence on a trader's economic calculations. Also, the practice of measurement works to ensure a certain margin. High prices, however, are correlated with rapid sales, but low prices do not always predict high gari turnover, nor do sluggish sales determine low prices. In the gari business a rapid turnover in sales is the most sought-after feature of success. Traders describe their best selling days in terms of rapid turnover rather than in relation to high prices. As one trader stated, 'Sales go well with plenty of customers.'¹

Unforeseen conditions can also arise. The most significant unanticipated and dramatic shifts in the price of gari are related to currency devaluation and petroleum strikes. In June and November 1993 gari prices per kongo jumped from ₦8 to ₦10 from the reduction of the petroleum subsidy. Weather conditions can also produce long-term differences in food prices and availability. Prices, however, are more

¹ Interview with Iya Bose, 22 February 1994.

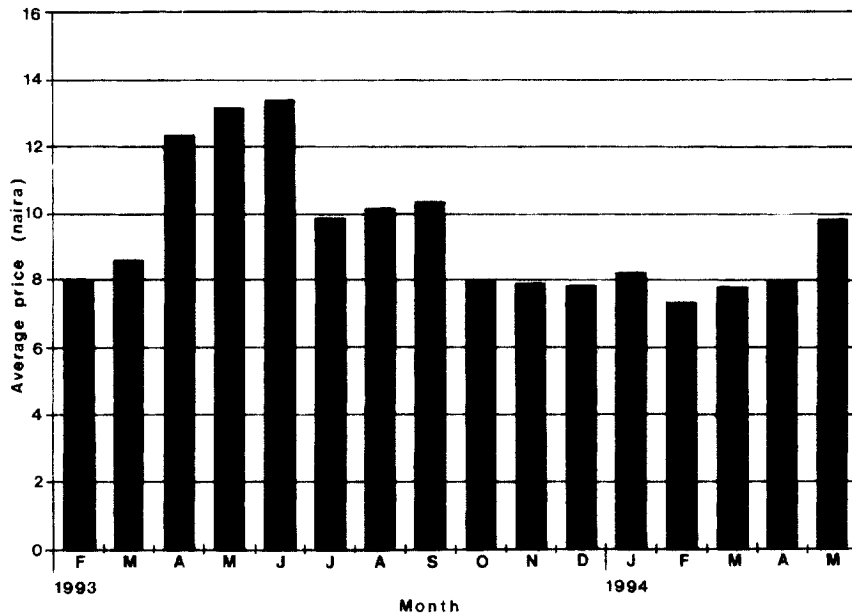


FIGURE 2 Average *gari* price per *kongo*, February 1993–May 1994. Source: Ibadan price collection data, 1992–94

likely to increase after several years of poor rainfall but are able to absorb differences in weather conditions within a growing season. As the example of February and March 1993 demonstrates, *gari* traders have limited ability to control prices. The supply of *gari* is a function of market price, but traders must risk their investment and immediate need for money to achieve acceptable returns.

Profits are differentially determined, depending on these phases of *gari* production and trade. Traders also try to ensure a level of profit for themselves regardless of the prevailing 'market' price. The differential volume of the measured *kongo* unit and the amount a trader's hand 'supports' constitute the minimal profit margin. Wholesale traders who also process *gari* and resell in Bodija and Orita Merin markets provide greater support to their *kongo* measures and therefore offer the best price in relation to volume. The differential amount of the supported *kongo* is contingent on the volume a buyer is purchasing. Therefore the greater the number of *kongos* a buyer purchases, the greater the amount of *gari* that is supported by the trader. Measurement is a differentiating factor between shops in Ibadan markets. As I describe in the following section, established shop owners differ in their approach to measuring.

This practice of measuring enables traders to assure a relative profit in relation to the fluctuation in prices over which they have little control. Although there is a flow of traders in and out of markets, traders themselves do not solely depend on the price of *gari* in the urban

markets to determine whether they will set out for the city to trade. The prices quoted by one trader on her return to an Oyo village may fluctuate by as much as 50k to ₦1 the following day. Traders have some flexibility in their price margins but ultimately limited ability to control the market.

Measurement, therefore, is one of the few practices that traders have direct control over. As I have described, the competitive and highly sensitive market for gari prevents individual traders from exerting direct control over price. It is measurement that enables traders to manipulate their margins of profitability. Given pricing practices in urban markets, traders are unable to dictate wholesale or retail prices. As I have noted, bargaining for gari prices is also unavailable to buyers. The price as paid by the customer, per measure of gari, obscures the two pricing systems available to traders.

MEASUREMENT AND PROFITS

In both urban wholesale markets in Ibadan, gari sellers appear strikingly similar despite differences in regional affiliation and trading level. At Bodija and Orita Merin markets, gari sellers cluster in selling stalls. In turn, gari shops are clustered into defined areas in the markets. Within a shop, every seller has an enamel garawa bowl filled with gari shaped in a perfect cone. There can be up to thirty gari sellers and traders in one shop, all selling at the same price. Although the sellers range in age from adolescent girls to elderly women, the gari is displayed in the same characteristic manner. This overall similarity in the retailing of gari is further accentuated by the uniform prices throughout the section of traders and shops. For the inexperienced shopper it is almost impossible to determine where to get the best buy.

In the smaller urban markets throughout Ibadan, in market stalls in rural village centres which dot Oyo state, and in roadside markets along the Ibadan–Abeokuta road, gari is displayed in perfectly shaped mounds of grain. One of the primary responsibilities of the gari seller (or *onigari*²) is to make her goods attractive to buy. Every garawa container in any market is brimming with gari. The buyer selects gari for its fine texture, dryness and grain size. To enhance the appearance of her goods, the trader sieves the gari. Fibrous pieces of cassava tuber and large grains are pushed down into the part of the mound closest to where the trader sits. By sieving the larger grains to the back of the mound the trader enhances the appearance of her goods. A trader spends considerable effort to replenish, sieve and landscape her garawa measure of gari. Buyers end up purchasing the nicely sieved gari as well as the larger pieces of fibre and grain. Once a purchase is made, the *onigari* mounds the grains again. During slow selling periods the *onigari*

² *Onigari* is a generic term for *gari* seller. The *oni-* prefix is used to indicate ownership and responsibility for the goods in question.

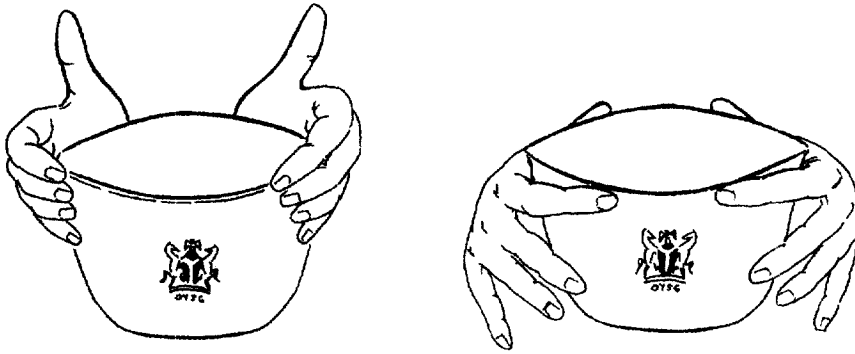


FIGURE 3 Measuring styles of an Oyo *kongo*. Sketch by Barnaby Thomas (1998), reproduced by kind permission

sieves the grains, and landscapes the mound to make sure that she has an attractive presentation. The fullness of the garawa displays in an overt manner the competence of the trader. The brimming fineness of the gari granules indicates the abundance that the trader offers. It is the abundance of food that is the attraction for buyers.

In an urban market like Bodija, there can be three different kinds of seller, each with a different margin of profit. For the novice buyer, making a decision about which gari to buy can be a daunting task. Although all the traders may be selling at the same price, they will not all use the same method to measure. Because each trader has a different profit margin, the style of measurement will reflect his or her trading volume. The oloko traders who have the highest margin of profit will 'support' the kongo, but the oniremi, retailer, who has purchased her gari from the oloko will have a much smaller profit margin and will not use her hands to increase the gari volume of the kongo at all. Consumers are unable to determine which trader is a wholesaler and which trader is a retailer before the measuring begins. Measuring is the single most important skill to acquire in the practice of the gari trade.

To 'support' the kongo means to measure the gari with both hands cupping either side of the bowl (Fig. 3). For the oloko, or the processor-trader, 'supporting' the kongo involves placing the ring and pinky fingers near the lip so that the hands collar the kongo and increase the volume of gari measured. This practice of measurement is accomplished in a rapid motion in order for most of the 'extra' gari to fall into the buyer's bag. Furthermore, supporting the kongo requires almost a full garawa. It is common to find retailers or oniremi traders drawing gari from garawa bowls. If a buyer is making a large purchase, the oloko trader draws from the nylon bag she brought with her and not from the garawa she is using for display. If the oloko were supplying the kongo from the garawa she would be replenishing the supply frequently.

While gari measurement is the responsibility of the seller, in large-volume wholesaling, measuring is increasingly done by the shop owner.

Previously the shop owner's primary function was to display wares and as the oniremi resell the gari from the oloko. The friction between different understandings about the responsibilities of gari measuring represents the shift from small-volume gari trading to expanding areas of large-volume trading. In small-volume trading, profitability may centre on direct control over each transaction's margin. However, in the expanding gari trade sales turnover is the new source of profitability. Traders who measure on their own may not be exploiting this new niche. In addition to a shift in the indicator of profitability, the single kongo measurement of enormous bags of gari presents a dramatic display that attracts a number of onlookers. Large-volume gari measuring would be an apt symbolic successor to brimming mounds of gari.

Shop owners from Oyo, such as Alhaja Lawumi, Mr Amos and Alhaji Oyeleke, do not measure gari for buyers. The measuring of large-volume gari is the sole responsibility of the onigari. These shop owners used to have shops in Orita Merin, claiming affiliation from Oyo town. They have been in the food trade for over fifteen years, and operate their shops according to the practices they learned during their apprenticeships. In the shops owned by Ogboro townsmen, Mr Afonja, Mr Fatai and Dele, large-volume gari is measured by the shop owner and not by the oloko. These shops are distinct from the Oyo-affiliated shops solely by virtue of the fact that they measure for the oloko. Also, these shop owners are relatively newcomers to the food trade. Two of them have moved into the gari business after years in transport and trade in Niger state.

This practice of measurement for the trader has become a sensitive issue for many shop owners. The rationale of the shop owner measuring out the gari for the buyer has always been that the oloko does not know how to measure properly for large-volume purchases. In some cases it may be true, since many oloko traders do not sell gari in such volume to one buyer. The shop owners who do measure claim that they can quickly measure out a large bag (conventionally called a 'Babangida bag'). Indeed, measuring out many full-size bags is an arduous task. Measuring must be performed kongo by kongo in Ibadan wholesale markets. The absence of weight standards and a fundamental lack of trust between buyers and sellers necessitate this labour-intensive task. In this instance there is no secrecy in relation to the *content* of a bag of gari; however, as I outline below, measuring styles do differ depending on the amount a buyer is committed to purchase.

An apprentice holds the bag open and as the gari is measured out he rolls the top of the bag down so that the shop owner can easily scoop and support the kongo. This measurement is done in full view of the buyer, who is counting kongos along with the shop owner. The onigari should also be in attendance, supervising the measurement and counting the kongos herself. Frequently, however, many buyers are purchasing gari simultaneously. In such instances it is difficult for the oloko to supervise every purchase, and she must depend on the honesty of the shop owner and his apprentices. Once the gari is measured out

the buyer pays the shop owner. The shop owner then deducts the commission for measuring and gives the money to the trader.

For many of the Oyo shop owners, the practice of measuring for the oloko in large-volume purchases is not a preferred activity. According to one shop owner, there is a tendency to cheat the oloko by saying that you measured one amount but agreed with the buyer on another. The buyer then kickbacks a portion of the difference to the shop owner or his apprentice. As many Oyo shop owners said, this type of deceit may not be discovered initially by the oloko, but at some point in the future the trader will know that her profit margin is not what she expected. Traders may come to a shop that measures for them but will eventually leave when they discover they have been cheated. To some extent this complaint is true: many traders shift their allegiance from one shop to another. Alhaji Oyeleke claimed that a group of olokos from Oke Ogun stopped offloading gari at Mr Fatai's shop because of a dispute over measurement. It remains difficult to determine the extent to which measurement inconsistencies occur. Certainly in very large volumes, such as those purchased for ECOMOG troops, there is graft and collusion between the buyer and the shop owner. But for the smaller purchases of up to 100 kongos it is difficult to document the level of graft on the part of the shop owners because there is such a loose idea of what profit margins should be.

Oyo shop owners clearly have no intention of measuring for the oloko. Apprentices may assist an oloko who must measure out a large volume. But the feeling amongst these shop owners is that the gari does not belong to them and therefore they cannot be responsible for the sales transactions. I also sense that the shop owners feel that misunderstanding can frequently arise from measuring, since margins depend upon the amount of 'support' that is given. These shop owners have extensive experience in the food trade, unlike the Ogboro shop owners who have recently entered the trade.

For the oloko who comes to Ibadan every other week, the greatest portion of her profit comes from the marginal difference. But, for the alarobo, measuring gari by the shop owner helps her turn the supply over quickly. An alarobo would prefer the shop owner to measure for her. Although her margin of profit is not as high as the oloko, her main goal is to sell off the gari as quickly as she can so that she can use the money to reinvest in another trip to the processing centre. In the case of the oniremi the measuring is always done by the seller. Oniremi are careful in measuring the kongo. They do not support the measure because they are the final sellers to the consumer. Within the three categories of traders, oniremis have the narrowest of profit margins. Their objective is to sell most of the gari on the day of purchase. They do not make huge profits, frequently selling at the same price at which they purchased the gari. They can perhaps hope to make ₦30 profit on a bag of gari purchased in one day. Some oniremi sell in adjacent stalls, especially those who buy on credit. But generally, oniremi sell in smaller markets in areas throughout the urban sprawl of Ibadan.

In summary, display and concealment are both present in measurement, and in fact only market participants with some expertise can distinguish one from the other.

DIVERSIFICATION AND CIRCULATING MONEY

Business accounting for Oyo Yoruba traders is a complex system of earmarking funds. This practice corresponds to the highly personalised concepts of money and profits held by women in the gari business and in the food trade more generally. With no written accounts, traders depend on dividing expenditure into discrete categories that aid their calculations and reconciliations. This also restricts the flow of funds into areas that may be subject to appropriation by children, husbands or other relations. Moreover, written records are not as immediate as a trader's memory and do not accommodate the peripatetic nature of trading. Although I suggest in subsequent sections of this article that money in Yoruba society and cosmology has profoundly public and moral qualities, women traders consider their earnings to be a private matter and highly personal. This mental practice of accounting accomplishes something other than managing the flow of money. Although many women are able to keep written records of their earnings and losses, none chose to do so. While women certainly comprehend the significance of their financial returns and losses, they have good reason to be wary of written records. Written accounts, as indicators of fiscal efficiency, create an abstraction of profits and losses that may shift the control over women's income beyond their immediate purview. Records can be discovered by others and therefore can become, like money, yet another item that requires safe keeping and secrecy.

The management of the constellation of goods that may have different selling prices, alternating sales rhythms and distinct seasonal cycles relies upon the storage of money on discrete areas of a trader's person. Funds for each food item are stored in a particular part of a woman's 'money belt'. Specially designed underwear and money belts, or *igbanu*, represent the foundations of a trader's accounting system. The back zippered portion of an *igbanu* stores all the profits from the sale of gari, the side-zippered pocket of the same belt holds all the money from on-going maize sales, while the front slot of the belt holds transport money. When the goods of a particular investment are completely sold, a trader takes out the money from the appropriate part of her belt or other storage garment and calculates her profit or loss. Women rarely keep large amounts of money on their person because the majority of their funds are immediately recycled in new purchases of foodstuffs, redistributed to children and other relations, or form part of weekly and monthly contributions to rotating credit associations. Earnings from the gari trade literally constitute the private matters of women. Oyo women store profits as close to their person as possible. According to Gbenga, Alhaji Oyeleke's apprentice, there are successive levels of fund placement, with the highest amounts of cash stored

closest to one's skin. Although there are significant dangers in storing money on a person's body, such as robbery, the mobility of the trader's life makes it difficult to place a large proportion of money in the bank.

Although the common practice among Oyo traders is to obscure the actual amounts of money they possess by hiding it in their clothing and scattering funds among different food commodities, the inflationary nature of the 1990s naira requires specific methods of counting and demarcating bundles of money. Scholars of contemporary Yoruba urban life have noted the persistence of traditional monetary units in the current naira economy. Traders in Ibadan and Oyo seldom refer to prices in naira currency. Rather, traders continue to convert naira prices into the pound sterling equivalents that were in use until 1975. There may be many conceptual reasons for the continued use of sterling categories, one of which may be that these traditional currency units are more efficient descriptors of large amounts of naira. In addition to the cognitive advantages, the use of naira currency categories immediately signals the ethnic affiliation of the buyer (Yoruba or stranger). Although non-Yoruba shoppers may be able to speak Yoruba, ₦8.00 can be translated in two ways to reveal the speaker's familiarity with the language. In modern Yoruba usage ₦8.00 is translated as *naira mejo*. The traditional Yoruba usage would translate the price as *àpò méjì*, or two bags of four. Therefore these currency categories indicate to traders the educational level of the shoppers and their 'market' savvy.

Some shop owners have bank accounts, but the majority of traders find that banks are inconvenient and inflexible places with specific hours of operation and numerous cumbersome procedures required for depositing as well as withdrawing money. Perhaps for many traders, banks are not only inconvenient but make funds unavailable for more pressing demands such as placing money in goods. Mr Amos describes the dilemma with banking:

A trader does not necessarily have savings in a bank. Our savings are in our goods. For instance, all the profits that I have been making this year were invested in a three-acre farm in Sooku. Only big-time traders can deposit in banks. Personally, I do not have savings in a bank because if an oloko brings goods for sale in my shop at this hour—4:30 p.m. to 5:00 p.m.—I will not be able to go to the bank to withdraw the money that I need to pay for the trader's transport. Then I would lose the chance to have her goods in my shop. [29 November 1993, Bodija market]

Money from trading ventures is used to augment other lines of trade or used for specific expenses. The daily expenditure on food and other miscellaneous items such as children's immediate school expenses and transport are financed from the daily proceeds of specific trade items. Money for such daily expenditure was also apportioned in women's garments. Unlike the more significant stores of profit in an igbanu, daily money was not as proximate to a woman's body. These small expenditures were kept in the small knotted portion at the tip of a woman's wrapper, *iro*, that is tucked into the folds of cloth. The term

used for alarobo food traders comes from the term *ro*, which means to wrap. Alhaja Lawumi related a common practice for storing money:

Usually when going on a journey for purchases of goods, the money is separated and kept in three places. The first place is to put the transport fare and food allowance at the tip of your *iro* such that you won't reveal the other money on you. The second place is to put some inside your *igbanu*, waist bag, and cover it with your *iro*. The money inside the *igbanu* could be distributed inside the different compartments of the *igbanu*, depending on the amount and type of *igbanu* being used. The third place is to put the biggest amount for the purchase inside a dirty bag or nylon [bag] such that anybody who sees the bag will not suspect or be interested because of its look. This is done as a precaution against armed robbers, who already know that we keep money inside the *igbanu*. The money in the nylon [bag] is then put inside other sacks that would be used in bringing the goods. [Alhaja Lawumi, 16 December 1993]

Unlike the *igbanu*, money at the tip of the *iro* is conveniently placed and more visible. In this storage area, women keep ₦1 coins and small denominations of bills that can be given out quickly to children or to pay for bus fares, etc. Accessing this 'pocket change' does not require a woman's partial undressing.

More significant household and family expenses such as children's school fees, purchases of cloth and house repairs are financed through earmarked trading items. Traders plan for expenses with scheduled pay periods, using two methods. The first method of saving is to designate receipts from one commodity line for a particular set of fees. Some traders put a sum of money in one purchase of gari, flour, beans or rice. The revenue from that initial investment is used to restock the commodity, and is continually recycled until the payment is due. According to Alhaji Oyeleke:

We don't save if the market is good. We always use all our money to buy goods but during the rainy season, farmers bring their goods to us, and during this time we tend to save some of our money. [Alhaji Oyeleke, 9 June 1993]

Specific goods therefore act as savings banks for particular expenses. Pepper, okra and other secondary ingredient food items may be apportioned to finance children's education or an upcoming wedding. Food items thus act as a store of wealth as well as a method of accounting. Traders diversify their investments in a range of goods in order to benefit from and insure against fluctuations or a sudden downturn in demand for one commodity line. In such an accounting system, where prices are highly responsive to transport, weather and currency devaluation, the naira currency is only a means of conversion and not a store of wealth.

The method that traders use to account for their profits structures the diversification of trading items. Specific expenses are considered in relation to how certain food items sell. For example, if okra sales make a

profit, a trader may be able to finance a metal roof, as planned. It may be only in cases of unfortunate events that earnings from one venture augment funds in another. Traders stated that the profits from discrete units of goods were maintained separately unless one line was not faring well. In those cases, experienced traders move their money out of the unprofitable item and into another commodity. Since the selling cycles are short, a trader is able to apprehend in a short time whether sales are profitable or not. Unprofitable goods may become profitable quickly and a trader can rechannel funds back again. The concealment system is therefore also a mnemonic for the trader for judging how her businesses are doing, and for making rapid adjustments.

POOLING AND DISPLAY

In this section I shift from the focus on women's incomes as diversified and cycling flows of funds to an examination of how the social network of family, friends, neighbours and other relations is forged and sustained. Oyo Yoruba women transform and establish their adult identities through participation in these social events. The flow of food and money that gari traders control not only funds ceremonies but also feeds the celebrants. Earnings from the gari trade form the basis of an open-ended circuit of reciprocal exchanges during life-crisis ceremonies, town celebrations and religious festivals, known as *àrìyà*. Yoruba social life demands material, social and political expenditure and, in return, grants moral identity. Participation in the festivals that celebrate and mark life crises both demonstrates and transforms individual and family status. The ability to organise a celebration attests to the social and political power of the hosts and the guests.

The Yoruba social calendar consists of a constant cycle of life-crisis celebrations that entail significant contributions of time, money and organisation. The economic anthropology literature concentrates either on the redistributive and equalising functions or on the mediating and safeguarding features of prestige ceremonies (Orans, 1975). Economists, on the other hand, characterise these social institutions as counterproductive or unproductive in relation to the objective of producing the most returns from the least investments. Both these perspectives attempt to explain this behaviour in relation to external principles. Assumptions about social wholes (cf. Mauss, 1967) and 'closed systems' notwithstanding, to use these explanatory tools to account for the continued effervescence of celebrations in Yoruba society at the end of the twentieth century would be to ignore the experience and meaning of women who struggle to organise, fund and participate in activities that make up a significant portion of their lives.

For the Oyo traders I interviewed, participation in ceremonies represents much more than an equilibrating mechanism, or a safety net, or even prudent fiscal practice. To attend a celebration of kin, age mates and other relations testifies to the social power of the participant. An individual's social power is manifested in the ability to bring a retinue of supporters to a function, all or some of whom will bear gifts

of money and food for the host or guest of honour. Scholars such as Peel (1983) and Barber (1995) have noted that contemporary Yoruba concepts of power, or *agbára*, continue to resonate with nineteenth-century Big Men symbolism and motifs. Big Men of the nineteenth century established themselves as autonomous nodes of information, people and goods outside the traditional royalist's landscape. They achieved their political autonomy by demonstrating their ability to mobilise people and goods in a self-perpetuating cycle of support and rewards. Oyo women traders have adopted these motifs in their struggle for social autonomy. Success in the food trade has enabled them to participate in and fund ceremonies and to establish identities outside the domain of the traditional affinal and natal compounds. Attendance at social events has become an important locus of female agency.

Yoruba personal autonomy is not conceived as an end in itself. To create robust social networks sustains a continuing flow of supporters and goods. This understanding of wealth and success that applies to families, communities, as well as individuals, contrasts with North American conventional assumptions about affluence which are premised on beliefs of limited and fixed resources. Celebrations and ceremonies, therefore, represent morally mobilising and personally validating practices in Yoruba social life. Of course, traders struggle to fund and attend ceremonies, and the continuing economic and political conditions create significant obstacles. Participation in *ariya* represents an enduring organising principle in Yoruba society that structures social relations, establishes personal and collective identities and contributes cosmological meaning. Economic evaluations of resource allocation to these practices overlook the multiplex and deeply embedded elements that ramify and constitute Yoruba social life.

Ariya ceremonies have become a constant feature of weekends. These ceremonies grew in frequency during the 1970s when Nigeria as a whole was awash with petroleum money. As metropolitan centres such as Ibadan, Ilorin and Lagos have spread in size and grown in population, ceremonies that create, affirm and realign important social relations continue to unite large networks of contacts, friends and kin living and working over a vast geographic area. And in the continuing political standstill and associated economic catastrophe that characterise contemporary Nigeria, *ariya* celebrations act as mechanism to circulate individual resources and provide a support system for the poor (Waterman, 1990: 177).

Distinct practices express social power in Yorubaland. The practice of arriving at ceremonies in matching cloth, referred to as 'and co.,' makes an impressive statement. Social power can also be expressed in the size or quantity of the gift. In the Oyo Yoruba conception, to achieve status transformation through participation in ceremonies, social power must be demonstrable and public. These particular displays of potency emphasise abundance and plenty, downplaying other characteristics of power such as skill, strength, aggressiveness and authority that may be expressed in more private and personal ways.

Sandra Barnes describes the purpose and qualities of a successful ariya ceremony:

In ceremonial undertakings, *idilé* [patrilineal descent group] mates as well as the wider kindred, affines, and even friends, are responsible for making contributions to the events. For those who have been conscientious in their ceremonial giving in the past, the generosity ideally will be returned twofold when they later stage their own ceremonies.

The ceremony is the symbolic demonstration of the host's resources: material and social. His own wealth and the contributions of his guests are used to make the occasion as satisfying for the participants as possible. In an effort to display generosity, hosts and hostesses buy and distribute gift items; their kinsmen or close friends also can bring and distribute gifts as an added demonstration of their mutual affection and support.

The ceremony binds together the whole social sphere of the host; it is a reflection of the host's influence and status. Kinsmen, friends, business associates, and political contacts are all gathered together in groups; a host's *idilé* mates may cluster together in one group; his in-laws in another; his voluntary association mates, work colleagues, and friends in still other sets. Social status is additionally measured by the numbers of guests, kinsmen and friends bring with them to the ceremonies. It is desirable that they bring guests, since it swells the number of celebrants and attests to the popularity of the hosts. [Barnes, 1974: 111–12]

Earnings from the gari trade support the immediate needs of a woman and her children. Earnings from a woman's entire trading portfolio provide funds for children's education, clothing expenses, saving for a house and the ability to participate in the round of festivals and ceremonies that create and establish a woman as a viable and active member of Yoruba society. With the exception of saving for a house, the most explicit purpose of accumulating material goods in the form of cash, food staples, cloth and other household items is for hosting and attending ariya. For Oyo Yoruba women, weddings and naming ceremonies represent important life-crisis celebrations that mark the transition to adulthood. Both ceremonies involve careful financial planning and organisation.

PLANNING A CEREMONY

Social networks are healthy and far-ranging in Yorubaland. Every weekend there are any number of ceremonies to attend in celebration of a wedding, a naming ceremony or a funeral. In addition to these major categories of ariya, there are other types of social obligation that require attendance—apprentices' freedom ceremonies, school graduations, days of religious observance, anniversaries of parents' deaths, and so on. And these life-crisis ceremonies are interspersed around the cycle of town and lineage celebrations. Ceremonies are a fact of life at the weekend in Ibadan and in towns such as Oyo. The information I collected from the urban markets and in the processing centre at Sabo indicates that work loads decrease during the weekend, falling off noticeably on Sundays (see also Guyer, 1997). As I have noted, a

person is frequently accompanied to ceremonies by members of a convivial association, or *egbe*. Members of an association are most likely to have similar costumes, and enter at celebrations *en masse* and chanting. Associations function as efficient and convenient groups of supporters. The growth and multiplication of associations based on town affiliation, marital status, occupation and religion may be attributed to the ready group of supporters that these associations can conveniently mobilise.

Many people have discussed the clear balance in the reciprocity of gifts and food, and, while there is an expectation that people should maintain some parity in their exchange of food, there is no absolute or standard practice to account for the exact exchange of ceremonial food between guests. By attending an ariya individuals enter into a cycle of reciprocity but, more important, individuals also enter a vibrant and active social nexus that may assist them in material, informational and spiritual ways. Waterman quotes a female chief in the following passage that describes the balanced reciprocity of ariya ceremonies:

When you were doing yours [hosting an ariya], I contributed. When he was doing his, I contributed. When other people were doing theirs, I contributed. So, if I'm doing a something, they should come and contribute, too. That's all! So that what you are going to spend, you may receive three times that amount. You make money, not only in spraying [cash gifts], but also in contributions. I bring food, I bring money, I bring this and that. That is the custom. If his father died, and he [the celebrant] is ready to spend, he will get a sponsor. All the people he had benefited from will come round to pay him back. And this is the only time an event like this happens. [Waterman, 1990: 174]

FINANCING A WEDDING: A CASE STUDY

The trade that feeds the family is also the means that sustains and extends social networks in gifts of food during weddings and other types of ceremonies. Hosting a celebration involves a meal for guests, entertainment, refreshments, covered seating and small gifts to mark the occasion. The two examples presented in this section describe the financial planning required to pay for food, music and rental furniture. Yoruba weddings and naming ceremonies also include culturally specific items that are exchanged. The following descriptions focus on the organisation and funding of the wedding of Segun and the granddaughter of Alhaja Lawumi, Basirat. Basirat's mother, Mama Waisu, an experienced trader from a well established Oyo trading family, planned the wedding, the matrimonial gifts and the main food items.

I present the celebration financing interviews of Mama Waisu in the following passages:

Mama Waisu. We have had some other ceremonies before and after the ceremony that took place in April. However, the marriage was the biggest

expense that I incurred this year. Most of the money that was used for it was from esusu contributions. I used the money I collected from my esusu contribution in buying things for the ceremony in bits before the big day. Some of the things I purchased were plates, china dishes and clothes.

Since I knew that the wedding would take place this year, about a year or so earlier I started purchasing in bits. I bought *aṣo òkè* about three to five months before the wedding day because its design and pattern vary quickly. To avoid having an obsolete *aṣo oke*, I postponed buying it until the fifth month before the wedding. I also bought about two dozen china dishes that cost ₦5,000. The dishes were not used for the ceremony at all. Rather I gave them to the bride on the second day of the wedding.

I have always belonged to an esusu club, long before the wedding day was fixed. I always made monetary contributions that the members collect in turn. However, with the date of the wedding fixed, the esusu contribution was targeted for the items I mentioned. Other items I bought were *elubo*, yam flour. Since *elubo* can be preserved for up to a year, I bought it about four months before the wedding date at ₦1,400 a bag. But during the wedding time, a bag was about ₦2,400. It means that I took advantage of my knowledge of the prices of most commodities to finance the wedding.

The tents and chairs that were hired for the wedding cost ₦3,000. From that sum I contributed ₦1,000, while my junior sister came up with ₦2,000. Other things such as palm oil, gari, beans, pepper, tomato [items for the stew] were gifts from friends because I have done such things for them when they had ceremonies.

The cow cost about ₦14,000, including the transport fare. We don't necessarily have a bank or savings account. What we usually do is buy a commodity that can be stored for a long period with money that is intended to be saved for future use, such as beans and *elubo*. These goods are then disposed of, sold about fifteen days to a few days before the date of the ceremony. In my own case, my ability to buy a cow for ₦14,000 does not necessarily mean or imply that I stored some goods that were worth ₦14,000 before the day. But on the day I went to buy the cows I had about ₦12,000 on me, the original amount that I had budgeted for the cow, but I ended up adding an additional ₦2,000.

In the above accounts Mama Waisu states that the wedding was not the only party that she planned during the year. The celebration was part of a broader cycle of ceremonies and events that make up the social schedule of established and novice traders. The purchase of items piecemeal over the course of time is a common strategy for individuals with a limited income; however, the planning of funds for such detailed purchases is complicated and requires a degree of patience to accumulate all the necessary amounts. A family that hosts a wedding or other elaborate ceremony cannot hope to feed all the attenders. The family usually plans on serving either the meat portion and drink component of the ceremony. The social ties of a family are demonstrated not only in the number of celebrants but also by the amount of food attenders bring to help feed others. People therefore not only come to eat and partake in the festivities but also come in literal support of the hosts. In return, members of the family will reciprocate at other ceremonies further along the calendar year or longer. Alhaja Lawumi's daughter provided the cattle to be slaughtered, but the

majority of the food was brought by guests of the family. The feeding of the party members, therefore, is truly a co-operative effort.

The description of ariya celebrations presented in this section has outlined the affirming, transformative and co-operative characteristics of a major social institution for Oyo gari traders in particular, and for Oyo Yoruba more generally. I have also noted that these celebrations require careful financial planning and preparation over the course of a year. How do the ariya celebrations with their corresponding cycles of reciprocity affect the long-term investments that traders struggle to accumulate? Do those investments in multiple and successive ceremonies drain scarce resources from traders' businesses? And do the investments in social relations, advancement, power and prestige represent unproductive economic practices?

Investments that Oyo Yoruba traders make in their businesses, in their children's education and in the wide range of social relations do not entail simple one-to-one calculations between fixed quantities of money, time and other resources. The first section of this article depicts accounting in trade as a complex and multi-temporal process where individual earnings and profits are diffuse. Although income from one commodity may fall below expected profitability, earnings from another line of trade can offset these initial losses. To determine the economic profitability of a trader at any one point in time becomes a difficult, if not meaningless, task, owing to the constant circulation of money and other material resources. Financing for an ariya ceremony becomes a distinct pool of funds, like children's school fees or shop rents, and corresponds to the general practice of earmarking money for specific purposes. Ariya ceremonies are planned undertakings for which people accumulate over the course of a year for immediate purchases or over many years in terms of reciprocal exchanges. Because every celebration is a co-operative effort, people do not have to invest all their savings and money in the ceremony. A large part of the ceremony is subsidised by the others attending the ariya.

Finally, social prestige and economic power are not distinctly bound conceptual categories and institutions in Oyo Yoruba political economy. Money and status in Yoruba social life are closely linked, but to be flush with money has no social meaning without some means of transforming it into a meaningful form of wealth. Karin Barber (1982) has argued that the flood of cash during the oil boom of the 1970s drew popular suspicions about whether this money that emerged quickly and with so little effort had illicit and immoral sources. The recycling of traders' profits into ceremonies provides recognisable as well as effective means of redistribution and status transformation. Yoruba understandings of accumulation and the power of money seem to incorporate both Marx's (1986) and Simmel's (1978) views concerning capital and money.

The contemporary Oyo Yoruba concept of money and accumulation emerges from the vagaries of riches and poverty experienced during the oil boom in the 1970s and economic retrenchment during the 1990s. According to Barber (1995), money is considered as a positive and

transformative force, if applied in culturally appropriate and recognisable ways. Money is sprayed on the heads, or *ori*, of recipients as a propitious gesture of acknowledgement and blessing. It corresponds to Simmel's view of the mobilising and uniting force of money. However, money merely *symbolises* prominence and prestige in Yoruba life. Money lubricates and mobilises social relations but cannot replace or supersede these fundamental elements of power. In this sense, Yoruba understandings of money reflect Marx's world view about the potentially dehumanising and alienating qualities of unbounded capital. Money, and hence wealth, are not abstractions but are the means of creating the socially dense nexus of Oyo Yoruba family, kin, friends, colleagues and neighbour relations that define and constitute success and achievement.

Ariya celebrations enable the host to transform and elevate his or her social status by relying on the collective support of age mates and other equals, the two enduring and mobilising dynamics of Yoruba culture and social organisation. The continued effervescence of celebrations and ceremonies that require substantial investment of a number of different categories of resources suggests that Yoruba notions of wealth and success are structured in fundamentally distinct patterns that may intersect at only one level with conventional North American assumptions about prosperity and achievement.

SOCIAL AND SPIRITUAL WELFARE

Within the last fifteen years Oyo women working in the gari supply to Ibadan have become successful traders. Their recent prosperity has not translated into unambiguous social success. Money has created opportunities for these women to support their families and find social autonomy, but money has also generated contradictions about women's social status and engendered conflicts regarding husbands' economic obligations to children. As described in the first section of the article, gari processors and traders diffuse their earnings through a variety of practices: in rotating credit associations, through disparate investments in food staples, and by reciprocal exchanges among kin and age mates. Women traders have actively sought to hide their money, with the literal storage of funds on their person as testimony to the dangers of revealing the exact quantity. The overall growth of the food economy in the Oyo-Ibadan region has also generated changes in some conventional practices and institutions. Some Oyo women have been able to translate their earnings from the food economy into socially recognisable investments such as ritual ceremonies and assorted ariya celebrations. Children and houses represent two avenues that women use to establish themselves as autonomous and viable nodes in the Oyo Yoruba social nexus. Women's wealth has increasingly been used as the sole source of support for children when husbands are not forthcoming with financial assistance. Their economic power and independence have forced women to shoulder more responsibility in the maintenance of households. Furthermore, Oyo women traders have also financed

houses outside their natal and affinal compound complexes, and established themselves along lines similar to traditional Yoruba compound heads and Big Men. Therefore the shifting concepts of wealth for Oyo women *gari* traders have employed traditional Yoruba markers of success and prosperity. This behaviour resonates with the larger themes of Yoruba social life, the dynamic between seniority and age mates that generates and structures social change and continuity in south-western Nigeria. Yoruba notions of seniority most often focus on the attributes of seniority. Concepts of childhood and attributes of children exist only in relation to children's importance for status, and do not detail the emotional and positive features of children themselves. Recent contributions in anthropology and African studies have focused on the meanings and conceptual issues surrounding parenthood and children (see Boddy, 1989; Cooper, 1992; Richards, 1998).

CHILDREN: THE EMBODIMENT OF SOCIAL AND SPIRITUAL MEANING

Gari traders state that the sustenance and provisioning of their children are the primary motivations for entering trade. These statements about raising children reveal the social, economic and spiritual importance of children in Yoruba society. Having children in Yoruba society confers a multitude of status markers, mobilisation nodes in social networks, accessible labour and cosmological identity. The description of 'wealth in people' speaks to the classical theoretical division between lineage mode and market-centred social relations. This typology blurs the detail and quality of people's experience and the importance of children in measures of wealth in any society. The classic structural functional view of children and descent and its mechanism for developing a wider politico-jural framework only begins to hint at the cosmological and personal significance of children.

Having children initiates and sustains social networks. Although marriage is the social institution that unites two families and their myriad connections, children bind larger networks of families, kin and other types of relations in their mutual sustenance of the child. Children, therefore, activate social relationships by establishing reciprocal exchanges between adults. The naming ceremony of a child entails the gift of names by important members of that child's life. Those individuals who are able to confer a name on a child initiate a patron-like relationship that may entail support of the child as he or she matures into adulthood. The reciprocal relationship may extend over the course of an individual's lifetime. In this sense, children function to unite age mates and to develop a process of exchanges of material and social resources along many temporalities.

In addition to the labour that children provide to their seniors, established adults frequently adopt young children into their households. It was common to find grandchildren residing in the homes of their grandparents. When I would visit older processors and traders they would be relaxing by playing with their grandchildren. This contrast of ages was particularly striking. Young and middle-aged

adults were frequently trading and away on supply visits to villages or travelling to Ibadan or Lagos and would leave their children with their parents. Moreover, young children would reside with their grandparents so as to provide company for their seniors. They would run small errands but, on the whole, were indulged by their grandparents. I would argue that the continuing importance of seniority over someone operates in this context. The defining principle of adulthood—caring for someone and being cared for in return—necessitates that young children remain well distributed in households. The notion of parentage, therefore, is much more fluid and flexible in the Yoruba context, not defined solely through relations of blood.

Given the social, economic and functional characteristics of children in Yoruba society, children and dependants make a substantial contribution to cosmological identity and perpetuity. The untimely death of a child or adult is a tragic and significant loss, but the death of an elder is a time of celebration and succession. Deaths represent the transition from a corporeal body into the pantheon of ancestors who can affect the daily lives of their descendants. To die without any offspring, therefore, presages a lonely and non-existent afterlife. Children celebrate the anniversaries of their parents and other family deities with food, celebration and recognition. Children, thus, represent the crucial link between the living world and the line of descent. Yoruba descent coincides with traditional notions of unbroken lineages of individuals that transcend time and space. Death, however, is a tangible concept in Yoruba religion and understanding. Ancestors have influence over events in the living world and their burial places are spiritually powerful locations. This aspect of Yoruba religion will be discussed in greater detail in the following section, where houses and social-spiritual power come together.

HOUSES: THE MANIFESTATIONS OF SOCIAL AND SPIRITUAL POWER

In Isale Oyo, where gari processing has taken on a factory-like atmosphere, incompleted houses populate the edge of town. They represent the profits and investments of women traders who have purchased land along the perimeter of the traditional city and built homes for themselves. Many of the homeowners do not reside in Oyo but live and work throughout the south-western region or in other areas of Nigeria. These houses are the retirement homes of many traders who will come back to their natal or affinal village to spend the final years of their lives after a long period of work and struggle. Ibadan, as the largest indigenous African city, is growing along its perimeter with new construction. Many of the buildings are built by women who have chosen to live in the city where they have no immediate senior family members and relatively few ties other than business. From my interviews, I learned that investments in land and houses were by far the most significant expenditures and goals of gari traders and processors. Far from the sound financial strategy of investing in land, women did not purchase land and invest in building solely for the economic returns. Houses represent significant social status

achievement traditionally associated with men. As women have taken on greater financial responsibilities they have also established themselves as autonomous social nodes in the nexus of Yoruba social life. By building a house and providing a place for her children and their children to reside, women have achieved a fundamental indicator of social autonomy.

Houses are the preliminary step to achieving *bibò àsiri*—the ability to cover one's basic expenses with relative ease. For many urban-based traders, paying rent is a distinctively modern and contemporary fact of economic life. The popular saying to 'own your own key' is a fundamental mark of economic and social achievement. Successful traders frequently live apart from their husband. Marriage provides women with status, legitimates children and forms the foundation of a household. However, men and women often have distinct measures of wealth. As juniors in an affinal compound, women are subject to the same structure of seniority among the affines of the household. In an effort to establish themselves outside these traditional hierarchies, women can form their own households where they are the most senior individuals.

However, it is not only the quality of being the most senior individual in the household that indicates a level of achievement in Yoruba life. The house must be filled with supporters, kin and friends to establish in no uncertain terms the status of the head. The Yoruba saying *ilésami ó dún jù Oye lo*, translated as 'It is better or more satisfying to have no family problems than to be given a chieftaincy title,' is *à propos* here. The desire to have a house full of people resonates with more historical notions of Big Manship and adds a distinctively Yoruba flavour to success in trade. The above statement suggests that what truly distinguishes success is not just the populating of a house but having a household that co-operates and is well managed.

It is not only the historical vestiges that endure in contemporary Yoruba urban life which encourage women to invest their savings in houses and buildings. Indeed, many women have become successful landlords from their investments. But the quality of communal living in these buildings mimics the traditional composition of compounds where domestic duties are easily negotiated and seniority and status continue as an organising principle. Houses in Ibadan, Oyo and Ogboro still represent the cosmological and spiritual power that family compounds, or *agbo ile*, embody. Women are thus able to establish themselves outside the traditional agnatic clan and organisation, and employ their earnings to create a social and cosmological identity independent of their husbands and fathers.

The symbolism and cosmological significance of houses are reflected in their use as burial places for their occupants. The traditional practice of burying people in the room in which they died continues in a modified form in contemporary Yorubaland. Although Christians have long been buried in cemeteries, Muslim Yoruba continue the practice of burial at home. Burial at home enables an individual's descendants to access the literal powers of the deceased. Relics, therefore, contain the *ase* of the deceased and that access translates into practical power in the affairs of business and life.

To build a home, therefore, is to prepare for the care of a family, from the most practical matters of providing a roof over their head to creating an eternal resting ground and maintaining spiritual protection from the ancestors for their descendants. This power, however, is distinct from the power of patrilineage ancestors who have been buried within the traditional agnatic compound. This new expression of power is derived from women's success in the local food economy that once merely sustained the day-to-day needs of children and now provides the longer-term spiritual place of a new kind of ancestor.

CONCLUSION

Success, in the local food economy of Ibadan, involves secrecy on many fronts. In the highly competitive market system, traders blur their roles as wholesalers and retailers, and put into place practices that ensure a certain level of profitability. Traders and shop owners circulate their wealth and plough profits back into a range of trading items to obscure their exact economic status to other traders and their families. Growth in the gari trade has set in motion some unveiling of certain practices while diffusing and obscuring others. Success in this context entails secrecy in a number of contexts. In relation to buyers in the gari trade, secrecy entails the obfuscation of the type of trader, the total amount of worth a trader maintains in food stocks and personal wealth. And successful traders also invest their earnings in social celebrations, their children's education and personal homes that all work to foster and enhance their social status and validate their wealth.

I have outlined how the daily business of gari trading supports the range of needs of a woman, her children, her extended family and her friends. The accumulation of profits is fundamentally and organically linked with the maintenance and support of the social networks that fund life crisis celebrations, and thus establishes personal identity and provides long-term spiritual distinction. While wealth for Oyo Yoruba women continues to be personal and, in some sense, uncountable, the growing commercialisation of the food trade has forced changes in traditional practices and institutions. Women's economic secrecy ensures personal control over their work and rewards and protects them against accusations of witchcraft and antisocial accumulation. Traders and many other people hesitate to enumerate how much money they spend and how many children they have. This kind of response and behaviour indicate that the two concepts are fundamental to the definition of wealth in the Oyo Yoruba schema. Just as *bibò àsirí*, or meeting personal needs, is the conventional expression of people's vague and imprecise material desires, wealth and success in Yorubaland continue to be tied to uncountable indices that maintain a balance and essential egalitarianism between age mates. Wealth, therefore, is constituted in distinct ways for Oyo Yoruba women. It is manifested not only in countless quantities of children and money but also in terms of infinite flows of customers, supporters and propitiants.

GLOSSARY

- agbára* Power
alárobo Type of gari trader who purchases processed gari and wholesales it at urban markets
àrìyá Celebrations involving music, food and dancing
àṣe Spiritual power
aso oke Woven cloth worn on special occasions
Babangida Bag Large nylon bag named for President Ibrahim Babangida, roughly 100 kg
bath A measure used only in gari processing, roughly equivalent to one garawa measure
bibo asiri A phrase describing the ability to cover one's expenses
búbá Woman's blouse
denge Oyo measuring unit
eba Starch paste made by boiling gari with water
ECOMOG Economic Community of West African States Monitoring Group
elubó Processed yam tubers
esusu Rotating credit associations
fufú Starch paste made from cassava flour
gààrì Grated and roasted cassava
garawa Measuring unit used to display gari in urban markets, roughly equivalent to thirty-two kongos
idilé Lineage
igbánu Money belt
ilé House
ìrò Woman's wrapper
iyán Pounded yam
kobiowu Measuring unit used in Oyo town
kongo Measuring unit used in Oyo and Ibadan markets
lafun Cassava flour
oloko Category of trader who cultivates her own cassava, processes it into gari and brings it to market. Some oloko traders purchase cassava from farmers but process and resell gari themselves
omo Child
onigari Generic term for gari trader
onile Shop owner
oniremi Category of trader who retails gari in urban markets
orí A person's head. Also used to refer to a person's destiny
òjá Cloth sash used to tie children to their mother's back
owó Money
pebi Type of measuring unit used in Oyo

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ABSTRACT

Competition, success and secrecy are fundamental characteristics of the local food economy of Ibadan, Nigeria. With the growth of the processed cassava, or gari, trade throughout this area, these characteristics are revealed in a number of contexts in the food trade. Traders and shopkeepers circulate their wealth and plough profits back into a range of trading items to obscure their exact economic status from other traders and their families. Success in this context entails secrecy in a number of respects. In relation to buyers in the gari trade, secrecy entails the obfuscation of whether the trader deals retail or wholesale, what she is worth in terms of food stocks and her personal wealth. Successful traders also invest their earnings in social celebrations, in their children's education and in personal homes that all work to foster and enhance their social status and validate their wealth.

RÉSUMÉ

Concurrence, succès et secret sont les caractéristiques fondamentales de l'industrie alimentaire locale à Ibadan (Nigéria). Avec l'essor du commerce du manioc transformé (ou gari) dans toute la région, ces caractéristiques se révèlent dans plusieurs contextes de l'industrie alimentaire. Les négociants et les commerçants font circuler leurs richesses et réinvestissent leurs bénéfices dans des activités commerciales diverses afin de cacher leur véritable condition économique aux autres commerçants et à leur famille. Dans ce contexte, le succès implique le secret à de nombreux égards. Concernant les acheteurs de gari, le secret consiste à ne pas révéler le fait que le commerçant négocie au détail ou en gros, ni la valeur du commerçant en termes de stocks de produits alimentaires et de richesse personnelle. Les commerçants prospères investissent aussi leurs revenus dans des festivités sociales, dans l'éducation de leurs enfants et dans des résidences personnelles, éléments qui contribuent tous à entretenir et à rehausser leur statut social, ainsi qu'à valider leur richesse.